

Asad Ikram

asad.ikram53@gmail.com · +44 7482 376417 · linkedin.com/in/asad-ikram98 · asad-ikram-mc.github.io/portfolio

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Re: PhD position, A Multimodal Analysis of Emotion, Narrative, and Migration Politics Online (Faculty of Social and Behavioural Sciences, Utrecht University)

Dear Dr Kim, Prof. Lubbers and Prof. Salah,

Governments increasingly read social media signals as public opinion, and the systems producing those signals cannot tell them what they most need to know: whether a surge of anger about migration is an organised narrative doing its work or a genuine shift in how people feel. I met this problem early. At Dubizzle Labs I led a three-engineer team running 500+ production scrapers across 15 MENA countries, and when Arabic Twitter and Arabic forums disagreed about the same event, I had no principled way to reconcile them. We could collect almost anything; we could not say what our data actually measured. That question shaped my Chevening application: I proposed using social media analytics to bridge the gap between government decision-making and public sentiment, and was selected as a 2024/25 Chevening Scholar from over 70,000 applicants across 160 countries. I have spent the time since turning that commitment into evidence.

My MSc Data Analytics dissertation at Portsmouth (Distinction, project mark 78, supervised by Dr Ella Haig) analysed 279,000 posts on UK economic policy across Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, ethics-approved and GDPR-compliant: a fine-tuned BERT at macro-F1 0.878, human validation at Cohen's kappa around 0.78, and NRC emotion analysis showing anger and fear driving negative reactions. The question it left me with was whether those four platforms were measuring the same construct at all. Dr Haig and I are now preparing a paper that treats each platform as a survey mode and applies psychometric measurement tools (generalisability theory, invariance testing and equating) to machine-labelled sentiment; reviewed by an ICWSM-experienced researcher, it is aimed at an arXiv preprint in late 2026 and ICWSM 2027.

Your vacancy puts the candidate "in charge of all aspects of data collection". That sentence is why I am applying. At M+C Saatchi Fluency I designed and operate the multi-platform social listening pipeline behind reports read by UK Government communications teams, tracking narrative shifts, misinformation dynamics and polarising themes across millions of conversations. I also wrote web-scraping-guide.com, a free public reference on web data collection, from legal and ethical constraints to anti-bot systems and production architecture. And multimodal analysis is not an aspiration but a running system: at ArtemisAI, my company, six production NLP endpoints including emotion run alongside CLIP visual embeddings across 111,000+ posts and 3.2 million comments. Migration narratives travel online as images with captions as much as text, and I already work with tools built for that reality.

All of this sits on one side of a divide: I can measure what circulates, but not how individuals interpret it, feel about it, or act on it politically. Your project studies exactly the half I cannot reach alone, pairing platform analysis with survey experiments and data donation, the two methods I most want to learn. Dr Kim's WebSci 2024 analysis of tweets on migrant caravans in the US and Mexico is the closest published work to what I want to do next. Prof. Lubbers' "Who Fears What?" showed that perceived cultural threat explains far-right preference better than economic threat, exactly the emotion-attitude link the project must now trace online. Prof. Salah's Data for Refugees challenge is my model for doing such work responsibly. I have not done migration research; I bring the measurement machinery and the motivation, and I want to learn the substance from you.

Against your profile: my MSc with Distinction meets the degree requirement; McNemar tests, bootstrap confidence intervals, chi-square and Prophet forecasting (MAE around 0.02) are my quantitative research experience; the self-initiated psychometrics paper shows I design my own quantitative research; my writing is tested weekly by government readers; and running Fluency, ArtemisAI and a paper in parallel has forced disciplined planning.

I am available for interview on 31 August and can start on 1 October 2026; as an international candidate I know visa processing takes around four months and would begin it the day an offer arrives.

Best wishes,
Asad Ikram

Chevening Scholar 2024/25 | MSc Data Analytics (Distinction), University of Portsmouth